

CSI:

CRIME SCENE INVESTIGATION



The Game's Afoot,

Based on the insanely popular CSI TV series (the original one, based in Las Vegas), CSI: 3 Dimensions of Murder has you as the new CSI (Crime Scene Investigator) on the team, solving some of the most difficult crimes in Las Vegas with some forensic science, detective work, common sense and a little help from your friends.

The game has you solving five different cases, our favourite one being the one with the murder of a big game company boss at the game's fictitious version of E3 (the Electronic Entertainment Expo) — heated opinions on the morality of violence in games, even broaching the subject of 'Why can't we all just play happy-fuzzy games?'

In each case, you need to build an 'Evidence Trinity' — a tool used by real-life CSIs — to form a triangular link between the victim, the crime scene and the suspect. Accompanying you on your sojourns will be one of the original CSI team, asking the questions that you may or may not think of, but are crucial to the progression of the plot — like revealing the shady past of a suspect.

The point-and-click interface of this game — after dozens of recent shooter, strategy and adventure releases — is oddly refreshing. There is undoubted appeal in using your brain more than your hands, and use your brain you must. You will be going through the standard CSI procedure: examining and searching the crime scene, analyzing evidence in the lab, and finally scoring warrants from the Brass to question, search or arrest suspects. While getting your criminal doesn't require you to be Sherlock Holmes, you can't sail through cases without paying close attention and exercising those gray cells a bit. When we played it with dulled senses in the dying hours of the day, missions took an average of an hour and a half, so don't expect to be stuck to this one for long.

For such a recent release, CSI: 3DoM looks appalling. The 3D counterparts of the real actors should have looked much better. However, when you consider its light system requirements, you see the sense in it all — this game was made to be enjoyed by anyone with a half-decent PC — hardcore gamer or not. It's saving grace is the voice acting, which is brilliant for the suspects you question, though a little bland for the original CSI cast. Overall, this isn't a title you should crave, but if you're looking for a break from the other genres, pluck this one off the shelves.

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Rating: 8/10; Developer: Telltale Games; Publisher: Ubisoft
Distributor: E-Xpress Interactive; Contact: (022) 2885 0245; Price: Rs 699

Minimum System Requirements:

1 GHz Processor, 64 MB DirectX 8.1 Compatible Graphics Card, 256 MB RAM